Watchful Mama Bear Gemini Wins the Helicopter Mom Award

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Even bears can be **helicopter** parents. The term describes parents who watch, control, and hover over their children all the time out of fear.

For being so watchful, the U.S. Forest Service team at Tongass National Forest in Alaska has given a brown bear named Gemini the 2026 **Helicopter** Mom Award.

"We understand her choice, weighing the dangers of being around other bears at a prime fishing location," the **rangers** write. "Still, we hope we see a lot more of them next year."

Gemini kept an eye on her **cubs** around other bears fishing in Alaska's Anan Creek. Brown bear **cubs** in Alaska have about a 50 percent chance of surviving their first year. Gemini has also had **cubs** in 2023 and 2024.

Word Treasure

helicopter -- Here, a parent who hovers over children all the time, like a helicopter hovering in the air.

rangers -- People who look after a park or forest and the animals in it.

cubs -- Baby bears.

Background you need

A helicopter parent is a parent who watches and controls their children very closely because they worry about danger.

Mother bears must protect small cubs, especially around other bears at busy fishing spots.

Salmon runs bring many bears to the same creek each summer, giving rangers a chance to watch them.

Break it down

WHO: Gemini, a brown bear, her cubs, and Forest Service rangers.
WHAT: Gemini won the 2026 Helicopter Mom Award for watching over her cubs.
WHERE: Anan Creek in Alaska, in Tongass National Forest.
WHY: Mother bears must protect cubs around other bears at busy fishing spots.

Why it matters

Watching over young animals helps them stay safe, just like grown-ups watching over you near busy places.

Test what you remember

1. What award did Gemini win?

(A) The Fat Bear Award
(B) The 2026 Helicopter Mom Award
(C) The Alaska Award
(D) The Best Fisher Award

2. Where did Gemini watch her cubs?

(A) At school
(B) At Anan Creek in Alaska
(C) At a zoo
(D) In a city park

3. What is a helicopter parent?

(A) A parent who flies a helicopter
(B) A parent who watches and hovers over children all the time
(C) A parent who never watches children
(D) A parent who lives in a forest

4. About what chance do brown bear cubs in Alaska have of surviving their first year?

(A) About 10 percent
(B) About 90 percent
(C) About 50 percent
(D) About 100 percent

5. In which years has Gemini also had cubs?

(A) 2025 and 2026
(B) 2020 and 2021
(C) 2019 and 2020
(D) 2023 and 2024

6. What do the bears at Anan Creek do each summer?

(A) Move to a city
(B) Sleep all summer
(C) Build houses
(D) Eat salmon and teach young to fish and survive

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: C 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Tongass National Forest rangers: Say they understand Gemini's choice and hope to see more of them next year.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):